

Yoga Sutra Agonistes: Hegel and the German Romantics

CHAPTER 4

Now freed from its Indian moorings, the *Yoga Sutra*'s westward drift next brought it to Germany, where Colebrooke's 1823 study was seized upon almost immediately by Georg W. F. Hegel, who was, in the 1820s, fully engrossed in his mammoth project of writing a world history of philosophy, and—to ensure that absolutely nothing would be left out—a philosophy of world history. Hegel's was philosophy on a grand scale. Decades before Darwin and nearly a century before depth psychology, Hegel's grand system sought to trace the evolution of the human spirit across the ages in a unique and idiosyncratic way. For Hegel, history was the stage upon which an abstract cosmic mind called the "World Spirit" evolved—from a state of unconsciousness to one self-conscious freedom grounded in ethical responsibility—by morphing into a succession of "folk" or "national spirits" (*Volksgeists*) spurred by the acts of "world historical individuals" such as Napoleon for Hegel's own time.

Hegel's death in 1831 cut short many of his ambitious works in progress; however, an outline of his reading of Indian philosophy, including Yoga philosophy, may be found in his now published lecture notes from the 1825–26 academic year at Berlin University. † Hegel made constant reference to Colebrooke in these lectures, albeit with no explicit mention of the *Yoga Sutra*. In those same lectures, Hegel made a point of mocking the writings of the brothers Friedrich and August Wilhelm von Schlegel, the founders of German Indology. Hegel's invective was particularly directed at Friedrich, the 1808 author of *Über die Sprache und Weisheit der Indier* ("On the Language and Wisdom of the Indians"), an iconic work of German Romanticism. Not known for pulling his punches, Hegel remained true to form here, dismissing Schlegel's understanding of Indian wisdom as superficial and grounded in religious rather than philosophical sources.

Hegel's most sustained discussion of the *Yoga Sutra*, viewed once again through the lens of Colebrooke's study, appeared in a set of critical essays published in 1827. Ostensibly written as a critique of two lectures presented on the *Bhagavad Gita* in 1825 and 1826 by the remarkable Prussian polymath, Wilhelm von Humboldt, Hegel's review articles, which were substantially longer than Humboldt's lectures themselves, were in many respects a pretext for settling a number of scores—† not only with Humboldt but also with the brothers Schlegel and, by extension, the entire Ger-

man Romantic movement. Unlike Hegel, Humboldt had a reading knowledge of Sanskrit, and his interpretation of the *Bhagavad Gita* was grounded in a linguistic analysis of its terminology. In this, he was following
 † in the footsteps of the Schlegels. Friedrich's 1808 publication—which we see Hegel belittling in his lecture notes—had been a truly groundbreaking work of European Indology inasmuch as it was the first German-language work to use original Sanskrit-language source materials in its presentation of Indian language, literature, and history.

† For the Romantics, who took their lead from the eighteenth-century enlightenment philosopher Voltaire, the golden age of humanity—the original fount of human spirituality and completeness, the lost paradise of all religions and philosophies—was to be found in ancient India. In contrast, the post-Enlightenment world in which man now found himself was a sterile, spiritually impoverished place inhabited by human “machines.” Only through the wisdom of the ancient Indians, they insisted, could fallen Western man hope to find his way back to his true spiritual home. Small wonder, then, that for Schlegel, the Indian sacred literature was the “pinnacle of Romanticism,” the source of all the world's languages, and “all the thoughts and poems of the human spirit.”¹ Furthermore, because the peoples of Europe and Asia were part of one vast family, ancient Indian philosophy lay at the origin of *both*
 † Eastern and Western thought. In the same way that the rediscovery of ancient Greek thought had spurred the

Italian Renaissance, Schlegel argued, the recovery of ancient Indian wisdom would give rise to a second, “Oriental” Renaissance.

Hegel had no such nostalgia for ancient Indian wisdom. Even if it could be shown that Sanskrit had been † the mother of ancient Greek and Latin, and even if India were the “original homeland” from which the Europeans first emigrated, all of these events took place in *prehistory*, and not on the stage of history—upon which India did not appear until its colonization by the British. As for the history of philosophy, it was, by definition, European history, the ascending arc of Western thought from the pre-Socratic philosophers down to German philosophers like Hegel himself. This axiom lay at the core of Hegel’s dialectic. With the awakening of consciousness to reason and moral responsibility in ancient Greece, the World Spirit, which had theretofore lain in a state of slumber, came to embrace the ancient Greek Volksgeist. Since that time it had metamorphosed via a succession of “Spirits of the Time” (Zeitgeists) through the vicissitudes of the Middle Ages and Renaissance—but always in the West, because the West alone was historical, and the † West alone had philosophy. In such a scheme, there could be no place for a parallel or convergent Indian stream.

To be sure, India had been a cradle of religion of a particular sort, but for Hegel this was at best an “anticipation of philosophy” in a culture that remained pre- † historical, forever outside the sweep of history whose

culmination, the complete self-realization of the World Spirit, was none other than the Volksgeist of the modern German state. In contrast to the freedom of the self-conscious mind that defined nineteenth-century

† Germany, the Indian mind had never evolved beyond a sort of dream state in which consciousness was incapable of awakening to subjective reason. As such, the Indian mind was nonphilosophical, with what passed for Indian philosophy being nothing more than Indian religion.

† For Hegel, the epitome of the dream world of the Indian mind was, precisely, Yoga, which he termed “the innermost core of the Indian religion.”² However, prior to Colebrooke’s 1823 study, the Yoga doctrine that both the Idealist Hegel and his Romantic sparring partners were focused upon had been that of the *Bhagavad Gita*, with its classical reference to the “three yogas.” It was this sacred teaching, already so highly revered by the Orientalists, that Humboldt was interpreting in his lectures—but behind Humboldt’s lecture stood August Wilhelm von Schlegel’s Latin-language translation of the work, as well as Humboldt’s own appreciation of the *Bhagavad Gita* as a full-fledged philosophical system.

Hegel’s reading of Colebrooke’s 1823 study greatly affected his view of the Indian Volksgeist. On the one hand, it seems to have forced him to reconsider, however briefly, the possibility of incorporating India into his vast tableau of the history of world philosophy. Since Colebrooke had clearly treated Samkhya as a

philosophy, Hegel was faced with the alternatives of either building it into his world history of philosophy or refuting its status as philosophy. But Hegel had another ulterior motive: Colebrooke's study gave him an opening to take on (and take out) both Humboldt and the brothers Schlegel, and to establish himself as the German authority on Indian philosophy.

In his lectures on the *Bhagavad Gita*, Humboldt † had defended August Wilhelm von Schlegel's translation of the term "yoga" against other Orientalist detractors, most notably the French Sanskritist Alexandre Langlois. Armed with Colebrooke's study (which he paraphrases extensively throughout his critical review), Hegel attacked Humboldt on this very point. For whereas Humboldt and Schlegel had translated † yoga as "absorption" (*Vertiefung*) and "devotion of perseverance" (*assiduitatis devotio*) respectively, Hegel took the position that the term was simply untranslatable: "Our [German] language cannot possess a word which corresponds to such a determination because the thing cannot be found in our culture and religion."³ Later, however, he would come around to proposing his own translation: for Hegel, yoga was "abstract devotion" (*abstracte Andacht*).

But the scope of Hegel's reprimands extended well beyond matters of translation, for the true aim of his review was to demonstrate that the German Romantics' vision of the *Bhagavad Gita* as philosophy was null and void, on the ground that the notion that Indian thought had a philosophical content was itself

null and void. To not attack Humboldt on this point would have been tantamount to allowing that India had a philosophy, and that it was, by extension, “historical.” So, indeed, much was at stake here. Commenting on a passage from the *Bhagavad Gita*’s second chapter (2.39), Hegel set up his argument:

† But Kṛṣṇa adds that what he has made Arjuna to consider was according to the Sāṃkhya doctrine; now however, he would take the standpoint of the Yoga doctrine. By this the entirely strange field of the Indian world-view is revealed. . . . Religion and philosophy, too, merge here in such a way that they seem to be at first indistinguishable. Thus right from the beginning the author [Humboldt] has called the contents of the poem . . . a complete *philosophical system*. In the history of philosophy there is in general great difficulty and confusion . . . [when one is attempting] to discover a special characteristic according to which such contents would belong to the one or the other region [i.e., religion or philosophy]. As regards Indian culture, such a distinction has now at last been made possible by means of extracts from truly philosophical works of the Indians, which Colebrooke has presented to the European public in the *Transactions of the Royal Asiatic Society*.⁴

Here it would appear that Hegel was admitting the possibility that India could have produced a philosophical system independent of religious dogma—

until he hoists Humboldt by his own petard (and with him Schlegel, since he notes that it is Schlegel's translation he is quoting):

As Herr von Humboldt points out . . . from the †
highest Indian point of view—as this is expressed
in *Bhagavad Gita* 5.5—this difference [between
Samkhya philosophy and Yoga religion] disap-
pears; both ways of thought have the one and only
goal: *The one who understands, that the reasonable*
(Sanc'hya Sastra) and the religious (Yoga Sastra) are
one and the same doctrine, is the one who verily
*knows.*⁵

But Hegel's coup de grâce (at least in his own mind)
came not from the *Bhagavad Gita* itself, but rather
from the *Yoga Sutra*. Referring to the “devout exercises †
and pious meditation” of the Yoga of Patanjali, Cole-
brooke had asserted that “because religious obser-
vances are more concerned than philosophy with the
topics there treated . . . the ritual of the *Yōga* . . . would
be a fitter subject of a separate treatise, rather than to
be incidentally touched on while investigating the
philosophical doctrines of both schools.”⁶ This was
Hegel's opening, and he took it by arbitrarily identify-
ing Schlegel's “devotion of perseverance” with the
practices outlined in the *Yoga Sutra*'s third chapter—
that is, with the techniques for attaining supernatural †
powers, which Colebrooke had dismissed as tanta-
mount “to a belief of magic.” At this point, the focus of
Hegel's analysis drifted from Yoga philosophy as found

in the *Bhagavad Gita* and the *Yoga Sutra* to the practices of yogis, as attested by the British in India:

† What here is called *assiduitatis devotio* amounts to what Colebrooke mentions with reference to *Patanjali's Yoga-Sastra* (3rd Chap.). . . . He says that this chapter contains almost exclusively instructions for physical and mental exercises. . . . Herr von Humboldt refers to this passage and concludes . . . that it seems that the gazing meditation of the Yogi would also have been fixed on other things than the Godhead. . . . The Indian isolation of the soul into emptiness is rather a stupefaction which perhaps does not at all deserve the name mysticism and which cannot lead to the discovery of true insights, because it is void of any contents. . . . Now what the Yogi first of all achieves through the devotion of perseverance is the miraculous ability of an *unlimited power*. . . . Yogis and magicians are . . . for the Indian *masses* synonymous terms. One could misunderstand this in the sense that the belief in such a power could only be found among common people. Colebrooke, however, remarks in that passage that the Yoga doctrine of Patanjali, as well as the Sanc'hya doctrine maintain that man can achieve in this life such a transcendent power.⁷

† Hegel concludes his review with a wholesale rejection of the Indian worldview as superficial, derivative, and utterly alien to the European mind. Yet it would ap-

pear that Colebrooke's study had planted some seeds of doubt in Hegel's mind with respect to Indian philosophy, which even his quarrels with the brothers Schlegel could not supplant. So we see him, in the two years prior to his death in 1831, returning to a consideration of the philosophical content of both Samkhya and the *Yoga Sutra*. Colebrooke's influence had already appeared in Hegel's 1827 review of Humboldt's lectures, for in them he had cast Yoga as the "midpoint between Indian religion and philosophy." Now, in his 1829–30 lectures on the history of philosophy, he returned to the *Yoga Sutra*, singling out its final chapter, on "abstraction or spiritual isolation" (samadhi), as "philosophy proper." In spite of this, he never took the next step of incorporating Indian philosophy into his grand scheme of the history of philosophy. It may be that death overtook him before he could do so. However, it is more likely that he never would have made such a move because Eastern philosophy could never have passed his litmus test for philosophy, which was the passage from abstraction to conceptualization. Therefore, just as history, which had begun in Asia, was "ahistorical history," so too Eastern philosophy was "nonphilosophical philosophy." † † †

For all his pontificating, bluster, and Eurocentrism, Hegel did prove capable, in the end, of at least lending serious consideration to Indian philosophy. This is no small thing. As Robert Bernasconi, from whose fine essay on this chapter in Hegel's intellectual biography I have drawn extensively here, concludes,

† after reading the *Yoga-Sutras*, Hegel granted that there had been an Indian philosophy and that we could learn from it. . . . Hegel was more open to the possibility of Indian philosophy, and more ready to look at the latest research about it, than many of us Western philosophers are even today. An examination of the way philosophy is taught in most departments in North America and Europe would confirm that the institutions of philosophy are still for the most part on the wrong side of even Hegel on this issue, and that should be enough to set the alarm bells ringing.⁸

If Hegel is deserving of some praise for his Teutonic blessing of Indian philosophy, and the *Yoga Sutra* specifically, as worthy of admission onto the stage of the history of “true” philosophy, he must nonetheless be faulted on another account. Here I am speaking of the ease with which he established himself as an expert on Yoga philosophy on the basis of his reading of Colebrooke’s short 1823 study. With no reading ability in Sanskrit and no access to the primary source material he was interpreting, he nonetheless felt himself authorized to pontificate on the (in)validity of Yoga philosophy as philosophy. As we will see, he was but the first in a long line of dilettantes, both Western and Indian, who have interpreted the *Yoga Sutra* on the basis of little or no understanding as means to furthering their own agendas.